2 YouTube Answer Mode - User Research

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Phase 2 — Research & Learn

Carried forward from Phase 1

Goal

Improve engagement and retention for knowledge-seeking viewers by helping them discover relevant, trustworthy content faster and with less effort.

Problems taken into research

1. **"I spend too much time searching before I find a video that actually answers my question."**
2. **"YouTube keeps recommending the same type of videos even after my interests have changed."**
3. **"I often skip through long videos trying to find one specific answer."**

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1. Objective and Methodology

The purpose of this phase was to understand how people actually use YouTube when they are looking for information, and to see whether the problems identified in Phase 1 showed up in their real behavior.

I focused on four things:

- What people do when the first search result does not answer their question
- How they react when recommendations become repetitive or irrelevant
- How they navigate long videos when they are looking for one specific piece of information
- What workarounds they use when YouTube does not get them to the answer quickly

I also wanted to see whether any new problems emerged that I had not considered in Phase 1.

Research sample

Method	Number	Who	Notes
User interviews, 30–40 min	24	YouTube viewers aged 21–38	14 knowledge seekers/professionals/students, 6 frequent entertainment viewers and 4 mixed-use viewers
Survey	60	YouTube users aged 18–40	39 identified as frequent knowledge/information seekers
Screen sharing	16 of 24 interviews	Mixed users	Participants demonstrated how they search, browse and navigate videos
Primary research segment	39 knowledge seekers	Students, professionals and frequent information seekers	Discovery and search questions were primarily analysed against this group

The interviews were semi-structured. Instead of asking people whether they agreed with my hypotheses, I asked them to talk about recent situations where they had actually used YouTube to find something.

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2. Persona

Arjun — The Knowledge Seeker

Age: 29

Occupation: Product/Technology professional

YouTube usage: 5–8 hours a week

Main use: Learning, problem solving and professional development

Secondary use: Entertainment

Arjun usually comes to YouTube with a purpose.

He may want to understand a technical concept, learn how to do something, compare products or get a quick explanation of a topic he does not understand.

He is comfortable searching, opening multiple results and moving between sources. He does not necessarily want to watch an entire video. Most of the time, he wants to get to the part that answers his question.

What he is trying to achieve

- Find a reliable answer quickly
- Spend as little time as possible searching
- Know whether a video is worth watching
- Find the relevant section of a long video
- Cross-check information when the topic matters
- Save useful content for later

What he typically does

He searches using specific questions, opens several results, checks titles and descriptions, and starts watching the most promising video.

If the answer does not appear quickly, he starts skipping through the video. He may increase the playback speed, check chapters or comments, or open another result.

For more important questions, he may also use Google or Reddit.

Main frustration

> **"The video might have exactly what I need, but I don't know where it is."**

The important part of this persona is that he is not necessarily looking for another video. He is looking for information.

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3. User Journey

Scenario

Arjun needs an answer to a specific technical question.

Stage	What he is trying to do	What he does	Main friction
1. Trigger	Solve a problem	Thinks of a specific question	Does not know which source will answer it best
2. Search	Find relevant content	Searches YouTube	Several results look relevant

Stage	What he is trying to do	What he does	Main friction
3. Evaluate	Choose a video	Looks at title, thumbnail, description and chapters	Cannot be sure the answer is actually inside
4. Start watching	Find the answer	Opens the most promising result	Has to spend time watching before knowing whether it will help
5. Navigate	Find the relevant section	Skips through the timeline	Finding the right point is manual
6. Narrow down	Get to the answer	Changes speed, checks chapters/comments	Still has to search through the content himself
7. Try another source	Solve or validate the question	Opens another video, Google or Reddit	More time and context switching
8. Complete the task	Get the answer	Eventually finds the relevant section	The answer may take only a few minutes, but finding it took much longer

What the current journey looks like

Question

↓

Search YouTube

↓

Several potentially relevant videos

↓

"Which one actually answers my question?"

↓

Open a video

↓

Watch

↓

Skip

↓

Skip again

↓

Change playback speed

↓

Check chapters/comments

↓

Find the answer

If that does not work:

Change the search → open another video → Google → Reddit → give up

The main friction is not simply finding content. It is getting from the question to the useful part of that content.

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4. What I Heard in the Interviews

Finding an answer often takes several attempts

A common pattern was that people rarely stopped after opening one video.

They searched again, opened another result or changed the wording of their original query.

> "The search results are usually relevant. The problem is figuring out which video actually has the thing I need."

Across the interviews, 18 of 24 participants described opening multiple videos before finding a useful answer.

The survey showed the same pattern. Among the 39 knowledge seekers:

- 31 frequently opened more than one video
- 17 changed their search query
- 21 searched Google for the same question
- 15 searched Reddit or another forum
- 11 eventually abandoned the search on YouTube

This tells me that the issue is not necessarily that YouTube has no relevant content. There is often relevant content available. The problem is the amount of work required to find it.

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5. Long Videos Create Another Problem

Long-form content was particularly difficult when people came to YouTube with one specific question.

> "I know the answer is probably somewhere in this video. I just don't want to spend 40 minutes finding it."

Among the 24 interview participants:

- 17 regularly skipped through long videos
- 14 repeatedly used the progress bar
- 12 changed playback speed
- 9 relied heavily on chapters
- 7 searched elsewhere when they could not find the relevant section
- 6 used comments to help locate information

The survey showed a similar pattern.

29 of 39 knowledge seekers said they frequently skipped through long videos.

24 of 39 had abandoned a useful video because finding the relevant section was taking too long.

This was particularly common with:

- Technical tutorials
- Educational lectures
- How-to videos
- Product reviews
- Professional content
- Podcasts and interviews

Importantly, people were not necessarily complaining that videos were too long.

They were frustrated when a useful video made them work too hard to find the information they needed.

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6. Recommendations Do Become Repetitive, But the Impact Is Different

The second Phase 1 hypothesis was also visible, although it did not turn out to be as severe as the first two problems.

22 of 39 knowledge seekers said they had seen recommendations continue to focus on a topic they were no longer interested in.

For example, someone might spend a few days researching a particular subject and then continue seeing similar recommendations afterwards.

> "I watched a few videos on one topic because I needed to research it, and then YouTube thought that's all I wanted to watch."

But users had a fairly simple workaround.

They searched manually.

Among the 39 knowledge seekers:

- 18 searched manually instead of relying on recommendations
- 16 ignored the recommendations
- 12 kept scrolling
- 5 left YouTube
- 2 stopped using YouTube for a period

So the problem is real, but it usually does not stop people from using YouTube.

They simply move to another part of the product.

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7. The Workarounds Users Have Built

One of the clearest patterns from the interviews was how many ways people had developed to compensate for these problems.

They use:

- YouTube Search
- Google Search
- Reddit
- Comments
- Chapters
- Transcripts
- Browser search
- Playback speed
- Skipping
- Multiple videos
- Saved videos

20 of 24 interview participants described using at least one external source or workaround when YouTube did not immediately give them what they needed.

Among the 39 knowledge seekers:

Workaround	Respondents
Search Google for the same question	21

Workaround	Respondents
Open multiple YouTube videos	31
Skip through a video	29
Increase playback speed	24
Use chapters	20
Read comments	17
Search Reddit/forums	15
Abandon YouTube and use another source	11

The important point here is that people are not necessarily leaving YouTube immediately when something goes wrong.

They are doing more work.

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8. Survey Results

Finding the right video

When asked how often they needed to open more than one video to answer a specific question:

Response	Respondents
Almost never	2
Sometimes	6
Often	15
Almost always	16

That means **31 of 39 knowledge seekers (79%)** opened multiple videos often or almost always.

When the first video did not answer the question:

What they did	Respondents
Opened another YouTube result	31
Changed the search query	17
Searched Google	21
Searched Reddit/forums	15
Abandoned the search	11

The dominant response was to keep looking.

Repetitive recommendations

When asked whether YouTube continued recommending topics they were no longer interested in:

Response	Respondents
Frequently	9
Occasionally	13
Rarely	11
Never	6

So **22 of 39 (56%)** experienced the problem frequently or occasionally.

However, the effect was generally limited to the recommendation experience itself.

Long-form videos

When asked how often they skipped through long videos to find a specific section:

Response	Respondents
Almost never	2
Occasionally	8
Often	16
Almost always	13

29 of 39 (74%) therefore did this often or almost always.

When asked what would make long videos easier to use:

Need	Respondents
Summary of the video	27
Search for a question/topic within the video	25
Jump directly to the relevant section	24
Automatic chapters/topics	22
Transcript search	19
Nothing / prefer watching normally	4

These responses point to the same underlying issue: people want to spend less time looking for the useful part.

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9. Assumptions Revisited

Confirmed

1. Knowledge seekers spend significant effort finding the answer they need

31 of 39 frequently opened multiple videos when searching for a specific answer.

The original hypothesis was therefore confirmed, but the interviews made the problem more specific.

People are not simply struggling to find a relevant video. They are struggling to determine whether the video contains what they need and then find that information.

2. Knowledge seekers frequently skip through long videos

29 of 39 frequently skipped through long videos.

This was also visible during the interviews and screen-sharing sessions.

The behaviour was particularly common when people were looking for a specific piece of information rather than watching for entertainment.

3. Recommendations can stop reflecting current interests

22 of 39 reported seeing recommendations that no longer matched what they wanted to watch.

This hypothesis was therefore supported.

However, the impact was lower than I initially expected. People usually dealt with the problem by searching manually or ignoring the recommendation feed.

10. What Was Not Confirmed

Recommendation problems do not appear to drive major YouTube abandonment

The original assumption was that repetitive recommendations could significantly damage engagement and retention.

The research did not support that strongly enough.

Only **2 of 39 knowledge seekers** said they had stopped using YouTube for a period because of recommendation problems.

Most people simply switched from recommendations to Search.

I therefore would not make recommendation repetition the main problem for this phase.

Users do not necessarily want shorter videos

The research also changed my view here.

People were willing to watch long videos when the content was useful.

The frustration came when they could not find the relevant information quickly.

So the problem is not:

> "The video is too long."

It is:

> **"The information I need is too difficult to find inside the video."**

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11. New Problems Discovered

It is difficult to know whether a video actually contains the answer

A recurring frustration was the uncertainty that exists before and during the first few minutes of a video.

Users look at the title, thumbnail, description, chapters and comments, but still cannot always tell whether the answer they want is actually there.

One participant described it simply:

> "I don't know if the answer is in this video until I've already spent five minutes watching it."

This adds another layer to the search problem.

The user has to decide not only **which video to open**, but also whether it is worth continuing once it is open.

YouTube gives users videos when they are often looking for an answer

Another pattern became clear during the interviews.

The user's intent is often very specific:

> **"How do I fix this?"**

But the result is usually a list of videos related to the topic.

The user then has to work out:

Which video? → Which part? → Is it relevant? → Where is the answer?

This is the deeper problem underneath much of the behaviour observed in the interviews.

Useful content can still be difficult to consume

Several participants described abandoning videos they considered useful because finding the relevant section was taking too long.

This means that even when YouTube has the right content, the user may not get enough value from it.

That matters because the problem is occurring after content discovery as well as during search.

12. Problem Scoring

All problems below are scored against the same goal:

Improve engagement and retention for knowledge-seeking viewers by helping them discover relevant, trustworthy content faster and with less effort.

Problem	Population	Intensity	Frequency	Total	Evidence
Knowledge seekers struggle to find the specific information they need inside long-form videos.	**4**	**5**	**5**	**14/15**	Population and frequency are directly supported by the survey. Intensity is based on the observed behaviour and abandonment evidence.
Knowledge seekers struggle to find a video that actually answers their specific question.	**4**	**4**	**4**	**12/15**	Population and frequency are directly supported by the survey. Intensity is my read from the interview behaviour.
Knowledge seekers struggle to tell whether a video contains the answer they need before investing time in it.	**3**	**4**	**4**	**11/15**	Mainly an interview-based finding; the score is my read of the evidence.
Knowledge seekers struggle	**4**	**3**	**3**	**10/15**	Population is supported by

Problem	Population	Intensity	Frequency	Total	Evidence
to get recommendations that reflect their current interests when those interests change.					22/39. Frequency and intensity reflect the mixed response and the fact that most users worked around it.

Scoring scale

Score	Population	Intensity	Frequency
1	A small handful run into it	Mild annoyance, easily shrugged off	Rarely, in edge cases
2	A minority of the segment	Noticeable but limited friction	Occasionally
3	A noticeable share of the segment	Real friction that interrupts them	Regularly, in some sessions
4	A large share of the segment	Significant friction that makes the task meaningfully harder	Frequently, across many sessions
5	Nearly everyone in the segment	Painful, or fully blocking	Constantly, in most sessions

The scoring makes the difference between the problems clearer.

The long-video problem has the strongest combination of frequency and intensity. Search friction is close behind it. Recommendation repetition is widespread, but the impact is noticeably lower because users have relatively easy workarounds.

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13. P0 Selection

The strongest finding from the research is not simply that YouTube search needs to improve.

The bigger issue is what happens after the search.

A knowledge seeker comes to YouTube with a question. They then have to select a video, work out whether it is relevant, find the right section and extract the answer.

The current journey is:

Question → Search → Multiple videos → Watch → Skip → Search again → Compare → Answer

This is why I am carrying forward the following P0:

> **Knowledge seekers struggle to get from a specific question to the relevant information on YouTube without spending substantial time searching, watching and navigating videos.**

P0 statement

Segment: Students, professionals and other knowledge-seeking viewers who use YouTube to learn or solve specific problems.

Problem: They struggle to get from a specific question to the relevant information because they cannot quickly identify which video contains the answer or where that answer appears inside the video.

What they do because of it: They open multiple videos, change search queries, skip through long-form content, increase playback speed, check comments or chapters, and sometimes search elsewhere.

Business cost: This creates friction during content discovery and consumption, which can reduce engagement, watch time, session depth and the likelihood of returning to YouTube for future information-seeking tasks.

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14. Final Conclusion

Phase 1 started with the assumption that knowledge-seeking viewers have difficulty finding relevant content on YouTube.

The research showed that the problem is slightly different.

People can often find relevant videos. What takes time is getting from the video to the information they actually came for.

They open several videos, change their search terms, skip through long videos, increase playback speed, check comments and chapters, and sometimes leave YouTube to search elsewhere.

The recommendation problem is real, but it did not have the same level of impact. Most people simply worked around it.

The strongest problem is therefore:

> **Knowledge seekers struggle to get from a specific question to the relevant information on YouTube without spending substantial time searching, watching and navigating videos.**

This is the problem I would take forward into Phase 3.